



A program of Partners for Sacred Places  
in collaboration with the  
National Trust for Historic Preservation



**2021 COHORT**

# Mount Zion United Methodist Church

**WASHINGTON, D.C.**

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Methodist Church in  
Washington, D.C., serves as a  
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**Mount Zion United Methodist Church** in Washington, D.C., serves as a “beacon of African American culture, history, and advocacy in this nation’s capital.”

Free and enslaved Black parishioners founded the congregation in Georgetown in 1816 following decades of discrimination within the Methodist church. The church campus embodies excellence in Black architecture. The original church burned down in 1880, but Black artisans and clergy erected a Gothic Revival-style church in 1884. John Anderson Lankford, the founder of Washington, D.C.'s first African American architectural firm, designed a brick addition to the church in 1887. The Mt. Zion Heritage Center, built by skilled Black laborers in 1811 and purchased as a community house for the church in 1920, is the only surviving English medieval-style cottage in the capital. The church's parsonage, where the first Black female UMC bishop was born, was designed by Black architect Calvin Thomas Stowe Brent. Mt. Zion served as a station on the Underground Railroad, and the congregation was influential in resisting the "back to Africa" movement, decrying Georgetown's gentrification, and organizing schools.

The Mt. Zion UMC congregation remains an active participant in community programming and activism. Along with six other churches, it runs the all-volunteer Georgetown Saturday Supper program, which serves meals to guests experiencing housing insecurity. The church also holds choir concerts, history tours, and carnivals that welcome all community members. Mt. Zion Cemetery served as the location of a National Trust **HOPE Crew** project in 2021, allowing a new generation of preservationists to gain hands-on experience through identifying missing graves with modern technology.

Through a National Fund grant of \$100,000 and an equal amount in matching funds raised by the congregation, Mt.

Zion will expand its physical capacity by upgrading spaces to be safer, more energy efficient, and more welcoming for community use. Work will include floor refurbishment and weatherproofing upgrades.

In partnership with the **African American Cultural Heritage Action Fund** and with the support of Capital One, students from University of District of Columbia (UDC) and Latin American Youth Center (LAYC) participated in a two-week **HOPE (Hands on Preservation Experience) Crew** project exploring Black history, D.C. historic landscapes, and historic preservation at Mt. Zion Cemetery.





Mount Zion United Methodist Church by Rev. Selena Johnson

Lafayette Avenue Presbyterian Church by Luis P. Gutierrez

# Stories and Media Coverage

# Partners for Sacred Places Newsletter

Partners for Sacred Places helps congregations and others with a stake in older religious properties make the most of them as civic assets in ways that benefit people of all faiths and of no faith. We are national, nonsectarian, and not-for-profit.

# National Trust for Historic Preservation Newsletter

A privately funded nonprofit organization, the National Trust for Historic Preservation works to save America's historic sites; tell the full American story; build stronger communities; and invest in preservation's future.

The National Fund for Sacred Places was established in 2016 to provide financial and technical support for community-serving historic houses of worship across America. The National Fund is supported by \$64 million from the Indiana-based Lilly Endowment Inc.

Partners for Sacred Places helps congregations and others with a stake in older religious properties make the most of them as civic assets in ways that benefit people of all faiths and of no faith. Learn more at [sacredplaces.org](https://sacredplaces.org).

The National Trust for Historic Preservation, a privately funded nonprofit organization, protects significant places representing our diverse cultural experience by taking direct action and inspiring broad public support. Learn more at [savingplaces.org](https://savingplaces.org).



**Please note:** In these materials, the term “congregation” is used to refer to the worshipping body or faith community of any religion including those that do not identify with this term (such as mosques/masjid). The National Fund for Sacred Places accepts applications from any faith tradition and seeks to provide inclusive programming and resources across religions.

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